> are priests, whose business it is to offer sacrifices to their idols. Some there are among them who addict themselves to natural philosophy and other sciences, but especially to astronomy, others to physic and pharmacy … They have many books, which contain an account of their religious ceremonies, much resembling the ancient Greek and Roman fables. They eat neither flesh nor fish, nor any other living creature, and drink nothing but water, nor do they ever eat before they have washed and bathed themselves. They are forbidden to eat any thing but what has been prepared by one of their own sect, for they rather chuse to die than eat any thing touched by one of another sect.

The wives of these Brahmins led severely restricted lives and were expected to follow their deceased husbands on to the funeral pyre:

> When a Brahman happens to die, his widow is obliged, as a demonstration of her affection towards her deceased husband, to burn herself. This is commonly done under the noise of several musical instruments, to suppress the doleful outcries of the dying person, and in the presence of their next kindred. They may excuse themselves as to this point if they please, but then they are branded with infamy, their hair is cut off close, which they must not let grow to any length again. They are excluded from the society of other women, nor are allowed to marry again.

Nieuhof also had plenty to say about those he described as the ‘vulgar sort’, with the Paraiyars considered ‘a wretched sort of slave’. Through his work with the pearl fishery Nieuhof knew these Paraiyars as pearl- and oyster-fishers, ‘they being the best divers in the world, from which they are accustomed from their first infancy’. But they were